These actions on the ground were combined with a sweeping public assurance of the impact of such measures. In the twelfth year after his coronation the emperor issued a public rescript in which he decided to explain with graphic detail how the practice of dhamma that he had instituted had led to a social transformation within his kingdom. This was obviously a king not content with merely elucidating the nature of the social change required, he was also interested in ensuring they had been made to happen and would subsequently benefit posterity. The edicts emphasize both that there has been a break with the past and the intent to ensure a transformed future for those who will come.

The repeated mention of past times in relation to the present was intended to highlight this change. Earlier, 'for many hundreds of years, slaughter of lives, cruelty to living creatures, disrespect to relatives and disrespect to the Shramanas and Brahmanas increased.'[8] Now, what had increased 'to a degree as was not possible to achieve for many hundreds of years in the past' was 'abstention from the slaughter of life, absence of cruelty to living creatures, seemly behaviour to Shramanas and Brahmanas, obedience to mother and father (and) obedience to the aged.'[9] He intended to ensure that this continued after his time: 'the sons, grandsons and great-grandsons of king Priyadarshin, Beloved of the Gods, will promote this practice of Dharma till the time of universal destruction and, (themselves) abiding by Dharma and good conduct, will instruct (people) in Dharma.'[10]

In the epigraphs of later kings, this kind of proclamation would become formulaic and used to underscore the permanent nature of what was being enacted, whether the grant of land or the construction of a memorial pillar. Ashoka's epigraph is novel in being the first in a line of inscriptions that made such declarations. It must nonetheless have appeared formulaic to his listeners because third century BCE audiences, familiar with sons murdering royal fathers and brothers, may have been sceptical of any king, however